Solid, Liquid, and Gas by David Quang Pham

OVERVIEW

Solid, Liquid, and Gas (Overarching Series)

To reinvent herself in an increasingly anti-science world, a struggling educator tries to secure a role in an educational television series that defined many childhoods.

Website: www.solidliquidandgas.com

Pitch Deck (Narrative / Production)

Completed Episodes (Screenplays)

1. Pilot – Inner Child
2. Who Does Not Belong?

Partially Completed Episodes (Screenplays)

3. Write and Wrong
4. For Educational Purposes Only

Stardust + StarPower! (A Children's Show in a Show)

Website:

Pitch Deck (Narrative)

Stardust

A cosmic mudpuppy named Stardust leaves glitter to help her human friend (Clay) and the viewer explore new worlds and learn science.

StarPower!

Stardust and her shape-shifting axolotl sister, StarPower, use their powers to help Aurora, Ray, and viewers save worlds in trouble and explore the universe.

Completed Episodes (Screenplays)

1. Pilot – Milky Way Sick Day

CAST OF CHARACTERS

TRINI "RAY" REYES is a struggling 29-year-old Filipina American educator and puppeteer with a passion for science communication. She often breaks the fourth wall to speak directly to the camera, sharing cynical thoughts about the world or her personal failures or asking the viewer to make a good or bad choice. She likes taking up space but is incapable of pausing to listen. She can speak Tagalog.

KWAN REYES is Ray's younger brother, an astronomy graduate student at Michigan State University and member of a local neurodivergent theatre. Unlike Ray's manic energy, he is grounded and uses scientific logic to calm down Ray. He and his dead-panned humor sometimes interrupt her fourth wall breaks. He can speak Tagalog.

MS. AURORA STARLING is a biracial educator with a huge following and the frontrunner to be the host of *StarPower!* Despite seeing Ray as a theatre camp and STEM club bestie, she is unknowingly seen by Ray as her longtime rival. She often breaks the fourth wall to speak directly to the camera, sharing positive thoughts about the world or her personal achievements.

BILLY CLAYTON DUBOIS is the original host of *Stardust*, now a middle-aged, cynical man. He left the show in 2006 due to his clinical depression and a drunk driving accident. He initially rejects Ray when she comes to him for guidance but soon comes to be her mentor after finding out that River and Skye are rebooting the series without him. He exhibits cartoonish energy and often speaks to an invisible audience, much like Ray. He frequently misses the camera's gaze, unlike Ray.

RIVER MATTHEWS is the co-creator of *Stardust* and its revival *StarPower*! She voices both titular characters. She is very protective of the brand and takes every chance she can to rid *StarPower!* of any flaw that *Stardust* had. Though she never breaks the fourth wall, she is aware of it like Ray.

SCHUYLER "SKYE" PARK is a co-creator and voice actor of *Stardust*. They are very open-minded and look out for Ray's wellbeing, unlike River. It may have something to do with causing Clay's 29th birthday drunk driving accident. In the early 2000s, they were male representing but have since come out as non-binary. Though they never break the fourth wall, they are aware of it like Ray.

LIST OF *STARDUST* + *STARPOWER!* CHARACTERS

STARDUST (voiced by River Matthews) is the title character of the original interactive educational children's TV franchise. She is a cosmic green mudpuppy who communicates by saying “twinkling.”

STARPOWER (voiced by River Matthews) is the title character of the spin-off reboot. She is a shape-shifting pink axolotl and Stardust’s bigger sister who communicates by saying “bubble.”

CLAY (played by Billy Clayton Dubois) is the host of the first show. In the reboot, Clay has since returned to his home planet and is a rocket scientist and appears as a recurring character.

AURORA (played by Aurora Starling) is the host of the revival series *StarPower!* and the second host of the franchise. She is Clay’s younger cousin and a musician.

RAY (played by Trini “Ray” Reyes) is Aurora’s courageous sidekick of the revival series. She often gets sent to scout inconvenient worlds. She becomes the third host of the franchise.

ROCKET (voiced by Skye Park) is a cheerful green-and-white ship who transports Stardust and her friends to distant worlds. In each episode, Rocket lands after the host sings “Rocket Zoop.”

SUPPORTING

TELESCOPE (voiced by Skye Park) is an insightful telescope.

GALAXY FAMILY are a spiritual family named after real galaxies

- MILKY WAY (little child)
- CARTWHEEL & WHIRLPOOL (teenage twins)
- BUTTERFLY (child)
- SOMBRERO (teenager)

MINOR

HALLEY (voiced by Skye Park) is a comet who delivers messages.

GRAVITY (voiced by River Matthews) is a stray dog who lets everyone down but can fetch anything. They bark “force.”

LOGLINE

In a last-ditch effort to reinvent herself, a struggling educator tries to secure a role in an educational television series that defined many childhoods, only to face the misinformed public and shadow of the original host.

GENESIS & THEME

It's exactly 3 decades since the premiere of *Blue's Clues*, a show that changed how we processed the world through kindness and pauses for us to participate. Fun fact: David Quang Pham's theatre professor was on the shortlist to be the host. Today's generation is growing up in a post-truth and anti-children's programming world with climate anxiety and scientific skepticism. *Solid, Liquid, and Gas* is a direct response to this. The story investigates the **states of matter** (solid, liquid, gas, including plasma) as a metaphor for personal transformation.

SEASON 1 (SOLID)

Ep	Title	Plot Summary
1	Inner Child	In 2025, struggling educator Trini "Ray" Reyes faces the end of her theatre career after accidentally incinerating her touring production's puppet show. Blacklisted and facing eviction, she finds hope in a viral video from Clay, the host of the childhood science show *Stardust* that once helped her and her brother, Kwan, survive family trauma. Ray travels to Michigan to pitch herself to the show's original creators, River Matthews and Skye Park, during an arts fair, but she is dismissed as unprofessional. After secretly recording a conversation where she learns a revival has been greenlit but that her polished rival, Ms. Aurora, most likely will host without any auditions, Kwan helps Ray track down a disillusioned, messy Clay in Brooklyn.
2	Who Does Not Belong?	When Kwan discovers that the show's creators, River and Skye, plan to hire Aurora without holding auditions, Ray and Clay film a rogue audition video at Clay's apartment. They leak the video online, where it goes viral and sparks a global wave of fan auditions. To avoid a PR

		disaster, the network is forced to scrap their plans and announce a legitimate casting process, officially putting Ray back in the running for the revival. Ray performs well and gains massive grassroots following, but the network ultimately chooses her professional rival, Ms. Aurora, for the lead role to ensure a safe image.
3	Write and Wrong	Despite Ms. Aurora getting the lead, the public demands Ray's involvement. Skye convinces River to hire Ray as a writer's assistant. Ray studies up on StarPower, Stardust's sister who was briefly introduced in a later episode of *Stardust*. Ray believes that because Stardust has a human companion with Aurora, StarPower should have her very own. She proposes it to the writer's room and River laughs it off while Aurora is very open to having Ray be her sidekick (a promise that Ray made in theatre camp was to never be Aurora's sidekick ever again), which River now considers can get the public to sideline Ray.
4	For Educational Purposes Only	The production of the pilot descends into a dysfunctional battle of hosting styles that threatens the revival's success. With the first day on set, where Ray arrives with an improvisational energy that clashes with Aurora's rehearsed professionalism. As filming progresses, the middle of the episode sees the set spiral into chaos; Ray's loud, unpredictable interjections constantly disrupt Aurora's scripted "learning moments," leading to expensive technical resets and visible frustration from co-creator River Matthews. By the end of the shoot, the production is left fractured and exhausted; rather than a cohesive educational show, the team is left with a pilot defined by a chaotic disruption of the calm they intended, setting the stage for the negative test audience reactions that follow.
5	Autopilot	The network screens the pilot episode, Milky Way Sick Day, to a test audience to gauge the series' potential. Ray and Aurora await the public's reaction to their clashing styles. The feedback proves disastrous: children and parents find the show crowded, expressing a preference for the simplicity of Aurora and Stardust, removing Ray and StarPower. River decides to keep Ray to humiliate her. The

		network decides to fund the full season anyway, leaving Ray in the painful position of knowing she is the "least favorite" element.
6	Listening Ears	Ray struggles to adapt to the show's rigid structure, feeling like a failure when she steamrolls audiences instead of pausing for them like Aurora. Ray refines her hosting style after realizing her direct approach resonates with neurodivergent children like her brother Kwan. She embraces this unique communication method, while the original creators and Clay express growing dissatisfaction with both hosts, creating an opportunity for her unique style to succeed.
7	A Safe World	The show takes a political turn when Ms. Aurora uses a segment on atmospheric science to discuss climate change. While she gains a following among adults for her activism, the network grows cautious. Ray makes a choice to remain neutral on sensitive topics. This decision to avoid political trolls creates an ideological rift with Aurora, who questions Ray's silence on social issues.
8	Won't You Be My Enemy?	Feeling marginalized by Aurora's dominance, Ray initially counter-protests anti-science events. She then accepts an invitation to a conservative streaming platform, choosing to bring her science ideals to a challenging audience as a challenge to Aurora's principles and the network's favoritism.
9	Sublime	Ray guest stars on a conservative streaming platform, attempting to prove she is brave enough to spread education to hostile audiences. The move backfires spectacularly; the public views her appearance as a betrayal of the show's inclusive values. During the next *Stardust* taping involving dry ice that explosively goes wrong, Aurora snaps, revealing the pressure she feels as a mixed-race woman who must be perfect, calling Ray a liability who burns bridges. The network fires Ray.
10	A Chain Reaction	In the wake of Ray's firing, the network brings back the original host, Clay, as a recurring character. Clay tells the audience Ray simply went off to college. Ms. Aurora begins to suspect that Clay's return is not

		just a favor to the network. She realizes he is planning to undermine her and use his influence. Meanwhile, Ray is picking up voice acting gigs to survive. She soon decides to volunteer at Kwan's neurodivergent theatre.
11	Save the Children	At the theatre, Ray initially tries to direct the neurodivergent actors with her overbearing energy on *Stardust*. However, she is humbled by them. They don't care about her fame. She's forced to stop talking and actually listen, learning that her role isn't to be the star but to provide support that allows others to shine. Meanwhile, Aurora escalates her advocacy by speaking out against a genocide in another country, despite the oppressor being a major backer of the network. She then goes on strike and leverages her following to demand Ray's return. She delivers an ultimatum to the network, stating that while she provides the mind of the show, Ray provides the heart, and the program cannot function without both. The network bows to the pressure and rehires Ray. However, Ray decides only to return as a writer.
12	The Boiling Point	Following their shared ordeal, Ray and Aurora reconcile and become genuine friends. Ray celebrates turning 30 and crashes her car much like what happened to Clay on his 29th birthday. This time, Skye takes the blame and gets suspended from the show. Just before the first season finale begins filming, Aurora accepts the host position of *Science*. She quits the show. The co-creators, River and Skye, are about to pull the plug on the series. Ray returns to take the mantle.
13	Outer Child	Ray hosts her first solo episode for the season finale, by a crowd of anti-science protesters gathered outside the studio. She masters the pause technique she previously struggled with, speaking her truth directly to the camera and receiving a positive response from children. Unknown to her, Clay is plotting to reclaim the hosting spot, and remove her with the show creators, setting up Ray as the active target of the next season.

SEASON 2 (LIQUID)

Ep	Title	Plot Summary
1	Back on Earth	Ray officially debuts as the lead host of *StarPower!* to high ratings. However, things become toxic when the original host, Clay, returns as a consultant. Clay begins a subtle campaign of gaslighting, whispering to the network that Ray lacks the spark necessary for the role. Meanwhile, the network begins development on the franchise's first feature film, sparking internal competition for the main character slot in the movie script.
2	Burnout	Production begins on the franchise's first feature film, *Stardust Goes to Earth*. Ray struggles under a grueling 14-hour filming schedule for this and the series' second season. Clay exploits her exhaustion, suggesting to the network that Ray may crack under pressure, mirroring the same burnout that led to his own departure decades earlier.
3	Hosts of War	After a tabloid leaks a video of Ray and Aurora fighting at a children's media convention, their networks force them on a kindness press tour, where they become enemies again. Aurora discovers Clay is sabotaging Ray but allows it to continue as she is against MCN's political stances.
4	Loud on Set	The production moves to real-world city locations. The harsh filming conditions, combined with random encounters from hostile anti-science activists and crazed fans, cause Ray's mental state to spiral.
5	Community Guidelines	Kwan's neurodivergent theatre visits the set for a Behind the Scenes special. When a minor technical glitch causes a small fire, reminiscent of the disaster that ended Ray's theatre career, Ray ignores the script and uses her puppets to calmly lead the group to safety, earning the crew's genuine respect.
6	We All Matter	After the fire, Ray is sidelined for a mental health break by the network. During her absence, Clay hosts a series of Stardust specials by revisiting past worlds. The episodes feel hollow, and viewership drops.

		She returns to her childhood home and finds her old *Stardust* VHS tapes. She discovers an unreleased episode where Clay accidentally broke a beloved puppet and had a breakdown on camera. She realizes Clay is a man who couldn't reset after a failure. Ray confronts Clay with the tape to show him she understands his pain. Clay finally drops his guard. He admits he was trying to sabotage her because he feared her success would make his own legacy obsolete.
7	Unscripted	As filming for the movie grows improvisational, Ray asks Aurora to return as herself. She accepts so long as she can use the film to advocate for the environment and wellbeing of children everywhere. They merge Aurora's musical talent with Ray's puppetry energy, creating a more balanced and inclusive production.
8	Opening Night	A special preview of the movie is held at a children's hospital. The event is chaotic; the children are rowdy, and an anti-science activist interrupts the talkback session. Clay reflects deeply on his own history with mental health.
9	Wish for Granted	In the Season 3 premiere, a terminally ill child actor named Grant guest stars. Clay officially retires, passing his signature cosmic vest to Grant. Despite Grant's wish for the show to continue, the network abruptly cancels the series, leaving only five produced episodes for the final season. Ray announces the news to the world on a book signing tour. Kwan also shares news to Ray that he is given an opportunity to audition for an acclaimed science documentary series.

SEASON 3 (GAS)

Ep	Title	Plot Summary
1	Absolute Zero	Ray watches the final episode of *Stardust* from 2006 to prepare for her last sign-off. She films it with the crew, which goes disastrously. Ray finds out that the latest FCC and its anti-science views had something to do with the show's cancellation.
2	Solid	Ray does Kwan a solid and coaches him on his audition for an acclaimed science documentary series. Kwan fails his audition. Years fly by as their government puts more anti-science individuals in power.
3	Liquid	After a 2038 hurricane disaster, the crew reunites as spokespersons for donations after nearly a decade since they last were together.
4	Gas	The nation faces massive education funding cuts, threatening to shut down libraries and science centers. Ray joins a grassroots movement with Ms. Aurora as a spokesperson. Their protests becomes a flashpoint for anti-science sentiment. An extremist group, agitated by the activists' stance against global injustice and funding cuts, disrupts the peaceful march. In a horrific turn, an anti-activist driver rams through the crowd, critically injuring Ms. Aurora. Ray is left holding her fallen rival on the pavement, realizing the battle for science and truth is now a matter of life and death.
5	Plasma	Following the horrific attack on Ms. Aurora, the nation is in a state of shock. Despite this, the anti-science extremist groups attempt to control the narrative, claiming the accident was the activists' fault.
6	Prima Materia	With Aurora hospitalized and the community reeling, Ray donates blood to her and uses the *Stardust* platform to launch a message about the importance of education and inclusivity. Inspired by Ray's courage, thousands of now-adult *Stardust* fans march on the capital, demanding the restoration of funding for education. Meanwhile, Ray attends the premiere of Kwan's science series that he created himself.